



CASE STUDY

University of Delaware Captures Insights to Inform Alumni Experience

The University of Delaware collaborated with Hanover Research to understand alumni career outcomes, campus engagement, and giving preferences.



THE INSTITUTION

University of Delaware

INSTITUTION TYPE

Public undergraduate and graduate university

LOCATION

Newark, Delaware

THE CHALLENGE

Investigate alumni perceptions to highlight the university's role in shaping professional pathways and to identify engagement and advancement opportunities

HANOVER SOLUTION

[Alumni Survey Research](#)

The University of Delaware (UD), highly values its community as "one university, many voices." Through its decade-long partnership with Hanover Research, UD has consistently focused on the importance of data in promoting the institution's long-term success. In 2023, Dr. Richard Reeves, Associate Vice President of Institutional Research and Effectiveness, and Dr. Heather Kelly, Director of Institutional Research, collaborated with Hanover to better understand the voices of UD's alumni community.

THE CHALLENGE: EXPAND THE BREADTH OF ALUMNI SURVEY RESEARCH

Drs. Reeves and Kelly wanted to expand upon previous research from the Office of Development and Alumni Relations (DAR) to measure alumni perceptions on the broader student experience before and after graduation. But to extend their capacity to take on this project, they partnered with Hanover's experts to design a survey that could appropriately capture these deeper insights.

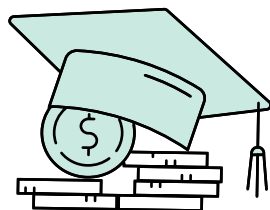


+17

The University of Delaware's
[Net Promoter Score](#)

"An earlier alumni survey centered on engagement preferences, but we needed insights into the overall alumni experience. Our new alumni study with Hanover gives us important benchmarks that make us want to do the survey again in two or three years to track our progress."

Richard Reeves, DProf, Associate Vice President of Institutional Research and Effectiveness



50%

The percentage of UD alumni who express interest in donating to their alma mater

THE SOLUTION: GATHER ALUMNI INSIGHTS TO UNCOVER EXPERIENTIAL HIGHS AND LOWS

With the help of Drs. Reeves and Kelly, Hanover designed, administered, and analyzed an Alumni Outcomes and Engagement Survey to investigate the following research questions:

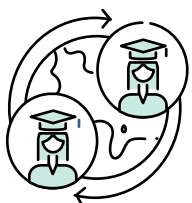
- How do alumni perceive their experiences at UD?
- How do UD alumni engage with the institution, and how would they like to engage going forward?
- How did UD prepare alumni for the workforce?
- What strategies should UD consider to increase financial support?

The survey captured alumni sentiments on their overall outcomes and satisfaction with their return on investment. Survey results addressed multiple UD units, including career placement, development, and academic areas — breaking down operational silos.



57%

The percentage of UD alumni who say their job is very or extremely related to their studies



200,000+

The total number of UD alumni around the world

THE OUTCOME: ALUMNI SATISFACTION INSIGHTS KICKSTART NEW INSTITUTIONAL APPROACHES

In January 2024, Hanover unveiled the findings of UD's alumni study, which the institution can administer longitudinally to track trends over time.

The study revealed many positive UD alumni attitudes and opportunities to strengthen graduate program pipelines and boost alumni engagement. In fact, out-of-state alumni reported exceptionally positive perceptions of UD, highlighting the university's ability to rally its community beyond state borders. Other insights revealed effective career connections with nearly 50% of alumni receiving job offers before graduation, and over 75% citing UD's efficacy in preparing them for their careers.

Based on the findings, Hanover's recommendations included insights on how to further improve UD's student and alumni experience and promote donor engagement, including:

- Prioritizing the establishment of alumni communities beyond Delaware to advance the institution's national and international presence.
- Encouraging networking and mentorship opportunities between alumni and current students to strengthen community and career connections.
- Implementing small-dollar donation campaigns to better accommodate alumni finances and areas of interest.

Armed with a more powerful understanding of their alumni base, UD leaders can develop new goals rooted in data rather than inference. The survey captured vital alumni attitudes and perceptions across the entire student experience. These findings will continue to guide UD leadership as they make strategic decisions about approaches to promote post-graduate professional career choice and placement, advancement, student success, and academic programming.

"There is an expectation that higher education institutions understand their students' experiences and outcomes. Hanover's alumni survey offered valuable opportunities for us to meet those expectations and bring about positive change for student and alumni experiences."

Heather Kelly, EdD, Director of Institutional Research
